THE EYE OF THE STORM

DHOLA INCIDENT

In early September 1962, a Chinese patrol came down the Thagla Ridge to Bridge 3 at the Nam Ka Chu and asked the men at the Assam Rifles post at Dhola to withdraw. According to the Chinese, the post was on their side of the border. The post commander held his ground, and the Chinese retreated. On 8 September, at 8 in the morning, a second patrol of sixty Chinese soldiers, armed with AK-47 rifles, came down the same route. Thinking that the Chinese had returned with intent, the JCO panicked and radioed Lumpu and Lum-la that a force of 600 soldiers was closing in on his position at Dhola.

The JCO's exaggerated reaction set in motion events that would eventually culminate in a full-scale attack by the Chinese. A force of 600 men roughly translates into a full-strength infantry battalion, and therefore it was not surprising that alarm bells started ringing, not just in Tezpur, but in Lucknow and New Delhi as well. The JCO's word was not questioned or further verified and even though the Chinese remained on the north bank of the Nam Ka Chu, the damage had been done. 7 Brigade ordered the post to hold its position, while additional Assam Rifles troops from Lumpu and Lum-la were told to move immediately to Dhola.

Brigadier John Dalvi was in Tezpur, from where he was to proceed on leave, which was cancelled and he was ordered to report to Tawang the next day. Other far-reaching decisions were also taken: as we have seen, 1/9 GR having finished its tenure in Tawang was in the process of entraining at Missamari on its way to a well-deserved peace station. It was told to immediately head back to Tawang, while 2 Rajput, on its way to Mathura after completing its three years in Walong, was told to stay put at Charduar and await further orders.

The next day, Major General Niranjan Prasad sent for Lieutenant Colonel Maha Singh Rikh and told him that 2 Rajput was to move into the